exchanges and linkages including facilitating BIMSTEC Business Visa Scheme and BIMSTEC Visa Exemption Scheme and implementation of BIMSTEC Poverty Plan of Action.

Three BIMSTEC Instruments were signed as follows:

[1] Memorandum of Association on the Establishment of the BIMSTEC Permanent Secretariat

[2] Memorandum of Understanding on the Establishment of the BIMSTEC Cultural Industries Commission (BCIC) and BIMSTEC Cultural Industries Observatory (BCIO)

[3] Memorandum of Association Among BIMSTEC Member Countries Concerning Establishment of a BIMSTEC Centre for Weather and Climate

Since March 2014, the Chairmanship is with Nepal.

Bangladesh Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina inaugurated the permanent secretariat of the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation (BIMSTEC) in Dhaka in September 2014. During the 13th BIMSTEC ministerial meeting held in Nay Pyi Taw in Myanmar in 2011, it was unanimously decided that the secretariat would be set up in Bangladesh and the first Secretary General would be appointed from Sri Lanka. The secretariat has been set up in Dhaka's diplomatic enclave of Gulshan. The first Secretary General, Sumith Nakandala, of Sri Lanka joined the secretariat in July and assumed office in Dhaka from August 2014.

The year 2015 was marked by series of meeting of BIMSTEC countries over a number of issues. The Sixth Meeting of the BIMSTEC Sub-Group on Legal and Law Enforcement Issues discussed counter-terrorism and transnational crime during 17-18 December, 2015 at New Delhi. Negotiations were held to outline the Draft Text of the BIMSTEC Convention on Transfer of Sentenced Persons.

The Second meeting of the BIMSTEC Network of Policy Think Tanks was held in Bangkok, Thailand from 08-09 October 2015. They focused ways and means of revitalizing cooperation among the Member States to further enhance people-to-people contact in the